Scaramouche Jones

By Justin Butcher

Scaramouche – (pronounced scare – a – **moosh)*

Scaramouche enters – an ancient clown with white face, red nose, wig, elongated slap shoes, baggy suit, etc. Slowly, balefully, he eyes the audience.

SCARAMOUCHE: **(Pg 4)** Allow me to introduce myself: Scaramouche Jones, Esquire – Clown . . . Englishman – or so I have always maintained, but thereby hangs a tale. Tonight is the last night of my life. As a million clocks strike midnight, I shall lay down my long and weary life. But before I go, indulge me by your attentiveness, my friends. Keep vigil with me and be rewarded with the Tale – and the Surrendering Up - of Scaramouche Jones.

INTRODUCTION

Orphaned, exiled and sold into slavery in a single day, Scaramouche's life was always one of discord. He was apprenticed to a Latin-speaking African snake-charmer, rescued by an Italian homosexual prince and spent time with Gypsies selling shoes in Poland. But those are each stories of their own. Today's tale is of Croatia . . . when Scaramouche, the strangely pale-faced child of a gypsy whore first became a clown. (Insert brief mime routine here)

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SCARAMOUCHE: **(Pg 27-30)** [September 1, 1939] The day that Poland fell. I escaped Krakow and the fury of the blitzkrieg by a matter of hours, fleeing southwards through Romania, disguised as a monk, with no clear intent but to depart these troubled northern realms forever. I walked, hitched, clambered on to the backs of trains and buses, speaking Latin to anyone who spoke to me and hiding my snow-white face under my cowl for fear it should excite comment. I reached the Adriatic coast finally in Croatia, where I was prevented from boarding a ship bound for Egypt by Ustashi soldiers, unmasked as some sort of impostor and slung into the back of a military station wagon – crammed with men, women and children who all bore on their garments a yellow star.

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The Nazi doctors could find nothing in their books of eugenic anthropology to account for the pristine whiteness of my face, but neither were they ready to believe that I was a thorough-bred Aryan, so they kept me alive as a curiosity that would bear further looking at, and gave me a job as a gravedigger at the concentration camp at Split.

My role in the 'Final Solution' was to dig mass graves, even in the bitterest winter when the shovel bent in the frozen earth, and then to stand by and watch as trailer-loads of dead bodies were u-ended into them. Sometimes presumably for the sake of variation, huge droves of living victims were herded to the edges of the pits and then machine-gunned into the ground.

However, the corpses arrived, whether by gas, bullet or malnutrition, my task was then to shovel white lime all over their contorted limbs and twisted faces – like the painting of so many clowns. So many clowns, millions of clowns – Jewish clowns, gypsy clowns, homosexual clowns, children clowns – all with white lime to cover their faces. It used to sting and burn horribly if you got it on your hands while you were shoveling it out of the sacks. [This] white mask *(gestures to his face)* was composed entirely of lime, the pain of which has never left me.

An extraordinary thing happened: I discovered a certain facility for making children laugh . . . yes . . . when those ranks upon ranks of frightened, worn-down people were lined up for the machine-gun squads, naked and shorn, one by one the children began to catch sight of me with my funny white face, leaning on my shovel, waiting to resume my work . . . and I would *(in words and in pantomime)* ***wink*** at them, ***pull faces, laugh hugely*** without a sound, ***cavorting*** and making fun of the guards behind their backs, ***acting out a silent pantomime of the execution that was about to take place***, pretending to be a victim gunned down, falling down into the pit and having my face painted white, then rising, fluttering on angel's wings, up into heaven.

I got caught fooling around in this way plenty of times and my punishments were far from pleasant, but it seemed to me a price worth paying, to see those haunted little faces fixed on mine as they waited for the end . . . and sometimes, just sometimes, one of them would almost break into a smile before the bullets ripped into them from behind and they toppled

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down, down, down and beyond the reach of pain or fear for evermore. And so the common euphemism for extermination in our camp became not going to the showers, or going for a haircut, but 'going to see the clown'.

This . . . honing of my training lasted until the Allied invasion of Italy, when the Germans fled, leaving me the sole proprietor in our particular establishment, leaning on my shovel at the edge of the last empty pit. I had dug it the day before for the last batch of surviving prisoners who were, as it turned out, saved by the bell. I was locked up, not surprisingly, for complicity in war crimes and there, in Spandau Prison, I mouldered, enduring the worst torments of boredom imaginable – having to listen to the interminable self-justifying raving and poisonous rhetoric of my fellow prisoners.

They talk about the death penalty these days; I've got a much better idea – take your condemned man and stick him in a cell with an old Nazi for seventeen hours a day and he'll wish he bloody well ***had*** been hanged.

My reprieve came in 1951, when my case, among others, was re-examined in the light of some of the stories the survivors of the camps were beginning to tell for the first time. The Hon. Justice Percy Rawlins, informed me that he had become intrigued by a particular clutch of testimonies regarding the 'white-faced gravedigger of the camp at Split.' Was I ***really*** the concentration camp clown whose antics had kept fear at bay for so many holocaust victims?

I muttered that yes, I had tried to make the little ones laugh before they . . . He was flabbergasted and asked me how, how had I done it? And so, standing in the dock at Nuremberg, I performed for him the Mime of the Comic Execution. *(performs the mime he used for the children)*

He remained silent for some time. 'It would sem that, in your own way, you have been of some service to humanity. You have been wrongfully imprisoned and shall receive your liberty forthwith. You are free to go.'

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(Pg 33-34) I purchased a pot of Leichner face paint and daubed on my final white mask – a magical poultice, a soothing salve to be applied and re applied like a dressing, night after night, year after year, in the dressing room of a clown. And I painted my smile indelibly into the white-scarred tissues of my face, like a wound. All that remained was to stitch the aperture with sutures strong enough to withstand the rigors of another fifty years of . . . . buffoonery. The threat of my life proved admirably handy and, in a matter of moment, my lips – along with my face – were sealed. And from that day forth and for the next fifty years, I never opened my mouth again.

So now you know . . . fifty years to make the clown, fifty years to play the clown. And now, I feel unmasked at last . . . I might dare say . . . almost free. **(Pg 26)** "Though your sins be as scarlet, yet shall they be as white as snow." [Isiah 1:18]

(Performs one final "good-bye" mime)

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AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier – MS
2021 National Qualifier
IL State Qualifier
CO State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

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